

Is your computer currently running a 32-bit or a 64-bit version of Windows? To see if your computer is running 32-bit or 64-bit Windows, do the following:

- Open System from the Control Panel
- There, you can view the system type.

Can you upgrade from a 32-bit version of Windows to a 64-bit version of Windows?

No. If you are currently running a 32-bit version of Windows, you can only upgrade to a 32-bit version of Windows 7. Similarly, if you are running a 64-bit version of Windows, you can only upgrade to 64-bit version of Windows 7. If you want to move from a 32-bit version of Windows to a 64-bit version of Windows 7, you'll need to perform a clean installation of the 64-bit version of Windows.

Can you run 32-bit programs on a 64-bit computer?

Yes. Most programs designed for a computer with 32-bit Windows will work on 64-bit versions of Windows. However, drivers designed for 32-bit versions of Windows do not work on computers running a 64-bit version of Windows. You will have to obtain 64-bit drivers for your devices, but you need not worry too much since most driver cd's these days come with both 32 and 64 bit drivers. Its only a matter of concern for older hardware, especially the ones for which the company has stopped support and updating drivers.

Would you benefit from using a 64-bit computer?

Yes. You will have more RAM available to you and you will finally be able to utilise your entire 4GB or higher amount of RAM. Apart from that, 64-bit Operating system is more efficient in handling memory intensive programs and from our experience softwares like Photoshop, 3D Studio Max and others which have separate 64-bit versions for 64-bit Operating systems run smoother than their 32-bit counterparts.

1.5 System requirements

Microsoft lists the minimum system requirements for Windows 7 on its website as:

- 1 gigahertz (GHz) or faster 32-bit (x86) or 64-bit (x64) processor (Windows XP stated this as 300 MHz; whereas Vista's bare necessity was the same.)
- 1 gigabyte (GB) RAM (32-bit) or 2 GB RAM (64-bit) (Windows XP needed just 128 MB minimum but again, it's the same as Vista's)
- 16 GB available hard disk space (32-bit) or 20 GB (64-bit) (Windows XP required just 4.2 GB in contrast whereas Vista for some reason stated 20 GB